nightmare or a bad B movie that condemns its audience to constant re- runs, the ‘images’ of the Zee News–Delhi Police Special Cell co-production collaborative genre of ‘terrorism’ refuses to give up its ghost. It returns to haunt our television screens, back-to-back with ‘Crime Reporter’ and a host of other sensational programmes that can only be described as a sad case of police-porn-snuff movies on late night but prime time television.

It returned to our screens momentarily when Geelani was shot by an unidentified gunman in Delhi on 9 February 2005. When earnest reporters and television news anchors across channels, for several days following the incident, instead of asking why the police were constantly shadowing Geelani, his brother, his friends, asked why his advocate had thought it wise to save his life by taking him immediately to hospital, and not waiting for him to succumb to his injuries as she went through the process of filing, first and foremost, a ‘proper FIR (first information report) as per procedure, with the Delhi Police’.

The night of 4 August 2005 was occasion for broadcasts on the final Supreme Court judgement on the 13 December case. These broadcasts, produced once again the latest (and perhaps last) episode in this continuing ‘B’ series TV show. Zee News produced yet another ‘special’ dovetailed into its prime time news show at 9 p.m. This time it was titled ‘13 December: Ek Saazish’. The news report showed a high-ranking Delhi Police Special Cell officer Ashok Chand (in a split screen with the first-ever viewing of surveillance camera footage from the Parliament on 13 December) offering an explanation of the splendid conduct of the Delhi Police in the case; after all, Afzal had been convicted as a result of the investigation. The others could not be convicted, because, as the reporter explained to the anchor in the studio, the terrorists had used high technology—mobile phones and laptops. And what this implied was that we need better and stricter laws to deal with such high-tech terrorists, so that no one would be able to get away. There is some irony in the fact that the very ‘high techonology’ which had helped the police write their charge sheets in the first instance, was now being blamed for their inability to fix the blame on say, a Geelani, on whom, the report continued to assert, the ‘needle of suspicion’ stayed firm and unwavering, though somewhat unsubstantially. So, mobile phones help catch ‘terrorists’, mobile phones are also so high-tech that they can be used by those ‘terrorists’ and their advocates to subvert the commendable work done by hard-working police officers. Therefore bring back laws, or make new laws that can make